

LOCAL NEWS APRIL 5, 2013

Help the food banks, thank the volunteers



LIBRARY COLUMN

George Williams



George Williams Associated Press

National Library Week begins April 14 and that means the Latah County Library District is about to run its annual Food for Fines campaign.

This year the campaign will run April 14-27. During this time, if you have late fees on any library materials owned by the Latah Library District, you can pay those fees by bringing nonperishable food items to any of our seven libraries. Fees will be forgiven at the rate of \$1 in fees for every item and everything we collect will go to local food banks. Food will only be accepted for the payment of late fees - you cannot pay for lost or damaged materials with donations of food.

We do this every year for a couple of reasons. For one thing, we like to give our patrons an alternative way of taking care of their late fees from time to time. More importantly, we run Food for Fines because it helps our communities. The library district operates branch libraries in Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Moscow, Potlatch and Troy. In the past five years the campaign has collected more than 3,500 pounds of food for local food banks in these seven communities.

So please come in to your local library during National Library Week and help your community by bringing in food for the local food bank. If you have late fees, we'll be happy to forgive them. If you don't have any late fees, we'll still accept any food you can bring us.

Also coming up during the week of April 21-27 is National Volunteer Week. Last year we had more than 30 volunteers who worked about 2,000 hours during 900 separate shifts. And that's just at our Moscow branch. Volunteers are important to the library district and help us in many ways. Some volunteers help with basic functions such as shelving books and DVDs, but our Board of Trustees, the Latah Library Foundation and all of our "Friends of the Library" organizations are made up of volunteers as well.

The library district's trustees, who are elected by the voters of Latah County, meet monthly and provide oversight for the library district. The Latah Library Foundation is a fundraising organization working toward building an endowment to help fund library services throughout the county (see the website at www.latahclf.info). Each of our library branches has its own Friends of the Library organization. Examples of the work the Friends do include the semi-annual book sales at the fairgrounds in Moscow, the remodeling work and installing new shelving at our Troy branch, and the recent series of programs on Idaho at 150 at our Potlatch branch. If you're interested in the work happening in Troy or the events at Potlatch, you can see pictures online at www.facebook.com/troylibfriends or www.facebook.com/154236917939174.

A big project the Moscow Library Friends have undertaken this spring is to help fund a major renovation of the front entrance to the Moscow branch. This project is set to begin soon and will require much of the time and energy that the Moscow Friends have to offer. As well as their money. Many of the Friends not only give their time to the library but also volunteer a little bit of cash through their dues, purchases of books and nickels and dimes voluntarily dropped into our donation boxes.

So, if you happen to run into any of our volunteers, friends, trustees or foundation members, please let them know that what they do is important for every person who uses one of our libraries. We try to thank them all the time because they certainly deserve as much for all the help they provide.

George Williams is access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

